Fruit and Vegetable Washer



Category: **Food Processing & Kitchen** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 1 labs

Covers these lab items: Fruit and vegetable washer

What it is used for

A fruit and vegetable washer removes soil and surface debris from produce using controlled water flow, sprays, brushes, or agitation. Correct water quality, loading, and sanitation help clean produce effectively while reducing bruising and cross-contamination.

Main parts

- Produce feed conveyor or loading basket
- Wash tank or chamber
- Spray nozzles, brushes, or agitation mechanism
- Water inlet, valves, and level controls
- Drainage and debris collection system
- Outfeed conveyor, control panel, and protective guards

Before you start

1. Confirm the produce type, required cleaning method, batch size, and downstream processing requirements.
2. Inspect the wash tank, brushes, spray nozzles, conveyors, guards, hoses, and drainage system for damage or residue.
3. Verify that the water supply meets the facility's approved potable-water and food-safety requirements.
4. Clean and sanitise food-contact surfaces according to the approved sanitation schedule.
5. Remove rotten produce, stones, packaging fragments, and other foreign material before loading.
6. Check that water flow, drainage, guards, and emergency-stop controls are functioning correctly.

How to use

1. Prepare the washer according to the manufacturer's instructions and fill the tank to the specified level if applicable.
2. Set the water flow, spray pressure, conveyor speed, and other controls according to the approved process.
3. Where the process requires a sanitiser, use only an approved product at the specified concentration and contact time.
4. Load produce evenly without overfilling the tank, basket, or conveyor.
5. Start the washing system and observe water coverage, movement, and removal of visible soil.

6. Adjust feed rate or approved settings if produce accumulates, collides excessively, or fails to receive adequate washing.
7. Monitor water cleanliness, drainage, spray performance, and produce condition during operation.
8. Replace or refresh wash water at the required intervals and whenever it no longer meets the approved quality criteria.
9. Inspect washed produce for remaining soil, damaged items, chemical residue, or other signs of inadequate cleaning.
10. Stop the machine if a blockage, leak, unsafe movement, or electrical fault occurs.
11. Isolate power before removing trapped produce, cleaning blocked nozzles, or reaching into moving mechanisms.
12. At the end of the batch, stop the feed and drain the system according to the approved shutdown procedure.
13. Remove accumulated debris and clean and sanitise the tank, brushes, nozzles, conveyors, and contact surfaces.
14. Record batch details, water or sanitiser checks where required, and any quality or equipment deviations.

⚠ Safety

- Only trained personnel should operate and clean the washer.
- Use water and sanitising agents approved for food processing and follow the specified concentration and contact time.
- Keep hands away from moving brushes, rollers, conveyors, and agitation mechanisms.
- Isolate power before clearing blockages or servicing moving components.
- Prevent cleaning chemicals and dirty wash water from contaminating clean produce or potable-water supplies.
- Use chemical-compatible gloves and eye protection when handling sanitising agents.
- Keep electrical controls protected from water and follow the equipment's approved washdown procedure.

Care & storage

- Clean and sanitise the tank, brushes, spray nozzles, conveyors, and drainage areas after use.
- Inspect brushes, belts, seals, hoses, and valves for wear, blockage, or leakage.
- Remove food debris and mineral deposits using approved cleaning methods.
- Check water-flow controls and emergency stops at the specified intervals.
- Arrange servicing if washing becomes uneven, drainage slows, or produce damage increases.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Using water that does not meet the required food-safety standard.
- Overloading the washer and preventing adequate contact between water and produce.
- Reusing dirty wash water beyond the approved limits.
- Failing to separate clean produce from dirty surfaces or contaminated equipment.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.

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